Chinese Companies in Africa: An Extension of Historical Chinese Labor Practices?

Introduction

Scholarly literature on China's relationship with Africa is vast, stretching from focuses on contacts before the Common Era[1] and the isolationist periods of the Ming and Qing dynasties[2] to the warming relations of the height of Mao communism[3] and the turn towards deeper political, military, and economic engagement of the Deng Xiaoping[4] and post-Deng years.[5] Now, with the rise of Chinese state and private investment in Africa to new heights under Hu Jintao[6] and Xi Jinping,[7] China-Africa scholarship has become more and more focused on this topic, and, more specifically, the role of Chinese companies in Africa and their use of local African labor. Paralleling scholarship, the general public, human rights organizations, and Western governments have also begun to pay closer attention to Chinese companies operating in Africa, with many of these groups worrying that Chinese companies are harming local African workers[8] or not benefiting local communities.[9]

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[1] Jinyuan Gao, "China and Africa: The Development of Relations over Many Centuries," *African Affairs* 83, no. 331 (1984): 241–50, http://www.jstor.org/stable/721561.

[2] Chris Alden and Cristina Alves, "History & Identity in the Construction of China's Africa Policy," *Review of African Political Economy* 35, no. 115 (2008): 43-58, DOI: 10.1080/03056240802011436.

[3] Tareq Y Ismael, "The People's Republic of China and Africa," *The Journal of Modern African Studies* 9, no. 4 (1971): 507–29, http://www.jstor.org/stable/160211.

[4] Ian Taylor, "China's Foreign Policy towards Africa in the 1990s," *The Journal of Modern African Studies* 36, no. 3 (1998): 443–60,. http://www.jstor.org/stable/161792.

[5] Barry Sautman and Hairong Yan, "Friends and Interests: China's Distinctive Links with Africa," *African Studies Review* 50, no. 3 (2007): 75–114, http://www.jstor.org/stable/27667241.

[6] Sautman and Yan, "Friends and Interests," 79.

[7] Cobus Van Staden, "China in the Era of Xi Jinping Thought: Five Key Trends for Africa," *South African Institute of International Affairs* (2018): 2-4, https://www.jstor.org/stable/pdf/resrep25945.pdf.

[8] "Zambia: Workers Detail Abuse in Chinese-Owned Mines," Human Rights Watch, Nov. 3, 2011, https://www.hrw.org/news/2011/11/03/zambia-workers-detail-abuse-chinese-owned-mines.

[9] Xiaoyang Tang, "Does Chinese Employment Benefit Africans? Investigating Chinese Enterprises and their Operations in Africa," *African Studies Quarterly* 16, no. 3-4 (2016): 107, http://www.africa.ufl.edu/asq/v16/v16i3-4a8.pdf.

However, despite much work, both scholarship and general interest on the topic of local labor in Africa-operating Chinese companies have a major failing: the lack of analysis of Chinese-local labor relations in the context of China's long history of labor practices. To be sure, the literature is filled with excellent analysis of African labor in Chinese companies using other lenses. Ching Kwan Lee, in her detailed ethnography of African workers in Chinese-owned and Indian-owned mines, takes a heavily Marxist angle, discussing the relationship between the local hires and Chinese companies with an eye to the theoretical dynamics between capital and labor and the concept of bargaining.[10] Xiaotong Yang, in two articles, takes up the concern of Chinese companies not hiring local African workers, digging deep into employment data and supplementing it with surveys and interviews of Chinese managers in Africa to find that these concerns, though valid, are vastly overexaggerated.[11]

And some researchers do take initial steps to connect their findings to histories of Chinese labor. For example, Anthony Yaw Baah and Herbert Jauch in *Chinese Investments in Africa: A Labour Perspective*, which looks at a variety of country case studies in Africa, have a brief section on the history of labor practices in China, though they do not make an explicit connection between these practices and those seen in Africa.[12] Only one article, though, makes the connection explicit: Fei Ding's on dormitory living and mining compounds for Chinese companies in Ethiopia, an article that connects these practices in Africa to their rise and origin in China.[13]

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[10] Ching Kwan Lee, *The Specter of Global China : Politics, Labor, and Foreign Investment in Africa* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2018), 78.

[11] Tang, "Does Chinese Employment," 110; Xiaoyang Tang, "Bulldozer or Locomotive? The Impact of Chinese Enterprises on the Local Employment in Angola and the DRC," *Journal of Asian and African Studies* 45, no. 3 (2010): 356, http://dx.doi.org/10.1177/0021909610364777.

[12] Anthony Yaw Baah and Herbert Jauch, *Chinese Investments in Africa: A Labour Perspective* (African Labour Research Network, 2009), 52-64.

[13] Fei Ding, "The Compound Labor Regime of Chinese Construction Projects in Ethiopia," *Geoforum* 117 (2020): 13-23, https://doi.org/10.1016/j.geoforum.2020.08.013.

What happens, then, if we choose to place current local African labor regimes in Chinese companies in the broader history of Chinese labor—what happens if we fill this gap in the literature? Not only do we gain heightened insight into the reasoning, expectations, and context surrounding a variety of controversial Chinese company practices in Africa, but we are also able to differentiate between those practices that have been implemented as exports of China's labor systems and those that have come out of local economic and political conditions. In this way, we will be able to add nuance to the debates raging about China's (lack of) local exploitation inside and outside the academic world. As a result, this paper aims to bring a historical Chinese labor perspective to two contentious topics in this field: low wages and poor working conditions for African workers (concern #1) and a lack of promotions and hirings for Africans (concern #2).

Contextualizing Today's Chinese Presence in Africa: A Brief Overview of China-Africa Relations

Historians naturally debate the date of the first contact between China and the African continent, but the first potential recorded contact dates to 100 BCE, when Emperor Wuti of the Han Dynasty sent an explorer west who came back with tales of a place called Likan, thought by some scholars to be Alexandria, Egypt.[14] From this period, China's indirect relationship with Africa, specifically through the trade of goods, increased throughout the Tang (618 CE - 907 CE) Sung (960 CE - 1279 CE), and Yuan (1279 CE - 1368 CE) dynasties, culminating in Admiral Zhang He's visit to eastern Africa by boat during the early Ming (1368 CE - 1644 CE) era.[15] However, later Ming and Qing (1644 CE - 1911 CE) isolationism resulted in the ceasing of these connections, connections did not revive until after the end of World War II, with the victory of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) over the Guomindang (also known as the Kuomintang).[16]

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[14] Gao, "China and Africa," 241.
[15] Alden and Alves, "History & Identity."

Under the CCP's Mao Zedong, China-Africa relations grew rapidly. The People's Republic of China, as the country was now called, released its "Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence" shortly after its 1949 victory, with the goal of enticing newly-independent nations to the PRC side with non-interference rhetoric.[17] Then, in 1955, the PRC foreign minister Zhou Enlai attended the Bandung Conference, meeting with top African leaders and opening the door for over 19 African nations to recognize the PRC over the Republic of China by 1965.[18] While relations cooled for the next few decades after that, with Deng Xiaoping, Mao's successor in the late 1970s, focusing more on the domestic PRC economy and its modernization, the West's condemnation of the Tiananmen Square Massacre of 1989 convinced Deng of the importance of re-focusing on Africa for allies.[19]

Since then, Jiang Zemin, Hu Jintao, and Xi Jinping's governments have continued to increase the PRC's involvement in Africa. Under Jiang Zeming, the PRC shipped billions of dollars in weapons to Ethiopia, the Congo, and Sierra Leone, and trade between the continent and the PRC rose to $10 billion USD in 2000.[20] Under Hu Jintao, PRC Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) to Africa rose to $8 billion in 2006, complemented by the $5 billion in the China-Africa Development Fund founded as part of the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation (FOCAC),[21] and the PRC took its first steps beyond economic relations with Africa, convincing the Khartoum government of Sudan to allow a UN-AU peacekeeping force in Darfur in 2007.[22] Finally, under Xi Jinping today, PRC engagement with Africa has reached an all time high. The PRC sent its

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[16] Alden and Alves, "History & Identity."
[17] Alden and Alves, "History & Identity."
[18] George T. Yu, "China's Role in Africa," *The Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 432 (1977): 97, http://www.jstor.org/stable/1042892.
[19] Taylor, "China's Foreign Policy," 444-446.
[20] Domingos Jardo Muekalia. "Africa and China's Strategic Partnership," *African Security Review* 13, no. 1 (2004): 8. https://doi.org/10.1080/10246029.2004.9627264.
[21] Sautman and Yan, "Friends and Interests," 80.
[22] Bernando Mariani, *China's Engagement in Conflict and Post-Conflict Settings: The Quest for Stability* (Edinburgh: PeaceRep, 2022), 28.

first-ever security troops on a UN peacekeeping mission in Mali in 2013, in 2016, PRC investment in Africa hit $100 billion, and, now, 37 out of 58 (~64%) African countries have signed on to the Belt and Road Initiative to receive funding for major infrastructure projects like light rail and hydropower plants.[23]

Concern #1: Low Wages and Poor Working Conditions

In this context of record-high Chinese investment in Africa, especially with the Belt and Road Initiative pushing connections, we look at the first concern brought up about local African labor in Chinese companies: low wages and poor working conditions, including job precarity. Despite the vast variety of Chinese enterprises, their diverse industries, and the varied countries and regions in which they work, these two concerns are practically universal. Workers in Chinese Zambian mines complain of "'slave wages,'" explaining that the Chinese mines easily pay the lowest out of all the global companies in the country and adding that casual and contract workers (which most of them are) earn the least out of all workers in the mine and face job precarity.[24] To the northeast, workers in Tanzania's Chinese textile factories faced similar concerns of job precarity, when the temporary workforce, making up 90% of the workers in these factories was summarily fired in 2007.[25] Back in Zambia, but this time once again in textiles, local workers faced the same issues of low wages and job precarity due to their casual status, despite by law being required to convert to permanent workers after six months' tenure.[26]

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[23] Jianwei Wang and Jing Zou, "China Goes to Africa: A Strategic Move?" *Journal of Contemporary China* 23, no. 90 (2014): 1120, http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/10670564.2014.898902; Van Staden, "China in the Era," 2; David Dollar, *Understanding China's Belt and Road Infrastructure Projects in Africa* (Washington DC: Brookings, 2019), 2-4, https://www.brookings.edu/wp-content/uploads/2019/09/FP_20190930_china_bri_dollar.pdf.

[24] Ching Kwan Lee, "Raw Encounters: Chinese Managers, African Workers and the Politics of Casualization in Africa's Chinese Enclaves," *The China Quarterly*, no. 199 (2009): 65, http://www.jstor.org/stable/27756495.

[25] Lee, "Raw Encounters," 652.

[26] Andrew Brooks, "Spinning and Weaving Discontent: Labour Relations and the Production of Meaning at Zambia-China Mulungushi Textiles," *Journal of Southern African Studies* 36, no. 1 (2010), doi:10.1080/03057071003607360.

Beyond Zambia and Tanzania, in South Africa, Chinese textile factories paid workers much lower than the minimum wage, a practice that was repeated in some construction firms in Ghana, Namibia, and Angola, though less egregiously.[27]

Aside from wages and job precarity, working conditions in Chinese-owned enterprises are also broadly poor and even dangerous. One of the biggest examples of dangerous conditions is the Chambishi Mines accident in 2005, in which 52 workers died in the Chinese-owned mines in Zambia.[28] Also in Zambia, one interviewed worker explained that, with the Chinese takeover of the mine at which he worked from a Swiss corporation, accidents quickly increased from once per month or less to three accidents a week, making the formerly safest mine in the country into a quite dangerous one.[29] Less dangerous, but no less poor, is the frequent ignoring of required breaks and meal times, with Malawi workers at some Chinese companies working for twelve hours without rest.[30] Chinese companies also tend not to pay workers for leave, including for sick leave or maternity leave, or not let workers know they have the right to these payments, resulting in female workers in Angola-based enterprises working right up to and shortly after birth.[31]

Can these low wages and poor working conditions have any relationship to historical Chinese labor systems? At first glance, the question, and the foundation of this paper, seems absolutely ludicrous. However, interviews with Chinese managers at Africa-based firms provide another perspective. They underscore the importance of 吃苦（chī kǔ, literally meaning "to eat bitterness") in their vision of the firms' operations and goals. 吃苦 is a Chinese philosophy that has been strongly prevalent over the 20th century, usually self-applied by Chinese individuals

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[27] Baah and Jauch, *Chinese Investments*, 67.
[28] Brooks, "Spinning and Weaving."
[29] Human Rights Watch, *"You'll Be Fired if You Refuse" Labor Abuses in Zambia's Chinese State-owned Copper Mines* (New York: Human Rights Watch, 2011), 52, https://www.hrw.org/sites/default/files/reports/zambia1111ForWebUpload.pdf.
[30] Baah and Jauch, *Chinese Investments*, 67.
[31] Baah and Jauch, *Chinese Investments*, 67.

when describing their abilities to handle major difficulties over that time period and beyond, especially during China's great modernization pushes in the latter half of the 20th century. In the case of firms in Africa, Chinese managers believe that, like the Chinese people struggled (吃苦) during this modernization, so too must Africans struggle in firms so as to improve their own countries' economies. As Tang explains:

> Huajian's [in Ethiopia] CEO Helen Hai told her Ethiopian employees to be patient and to have foresight when they demanded a raise. She reminded them that [the] Chinese were also poor thirty years ago and it took time and hard work to finally become successful.[32]

Tang also adds, with regards to Chinese views of living and working conditions related to Chinese-owned firms in Africa:

> Almost every Chinese views the harsh conditions as necessary costs for development. In the Huajian factory, over one hundred male Chinese workers and supervisors slept together in one room behind the workshop. When I met these young men, they had already stayed there for six months and would stay for another one or two years. They admitted that there was a lot of inconvenience in living, but it is not a bad thing for young people to "eat bitterness."[33]

Lee finds similar views on the need to suffer for progress among Chinese managers at the Urafiki textile mill based in Tanzania. She explains that the managers she interviewed "constantly referred to 'eating bitterness' when speaking about their experience in Tanzania," detailing to her the issues they faced when first taking over the factory in the late 1990s, including power and water service outages, terrible living conditions, and the drought of 1997, in

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[32] Tang, "Does Chinese Employment," 113.
[33] Tang, "Does Chinese Employment," 114.

which the Chinese team completely ran out water and was forced to sterilize the water from an old tub filled with dirt and dead mice to survive.[34] Once again, the managers brought in China's development experience, with one senior manager stating: "Mr Swai [a Tanzanian colleague] has seen how China was once backward and poor too. People did not have cell phones or televisions. Why did the country develop? We eat bitterness and make sacrifices."[35] He then went on to complain that Africans do not understand this need to sacrifice for their countries, such as in the form of poor work conditions and low wages, while "China's reform experience has taught us that you need sacrifice. Our own industrial enterprises have turned the corner from losing money to making profits by intensifying the labour process and reducing manpower."[36] Chinese companies expect local African workers to accept poor conditions, including low wages and heightened danger, as a necessary prerequisite for the eventual development of their countries through this labor, which they dogmatically believe is the main goal of their African workers in working at these firms.

Having discussed the 吃苦 mindset and its relationship to the ultimate goal, in Chinese managers' eyes, of country development, Chinese firms' choice to rely primarily on non-permanent labor, especially into the new millennium, also becomes clearer. When the PRC moved out of the strict socialist labor structures of the Mao years (characterized by long tenure at a single state-owned enterprise) with the goal of developing the economy as quickly as possible, the state quickly turned to large pools of migrant workers

[34] Lee, "Raw Encounters," 655-656.
[35] Lee, "Raw Encounters," 656.
[36] Lee, "Raw Encounters," 656.

from the countryside and their flexible tenure for cheap labor. In the Special Economic Zones (SEZs) set up in the 1980s to maximize incentives for foreign investment, the PRC directly offered outside investors cheap labor in the so-called "three-plus-one" (三来一补) scheme, promising this low-cost labor if investors established export-focused factories, brought their technology, and imported the necessary raw materials.[37]

As local Shenzhen residents soon grew tired of the terrible conditions and low pay, the state loosened the rigid urban/rural residential divisions to entice "a massive number of young people from poor villages in inland provinces, desperate to escape rural poverty," to come to Shenzhen and work. There, "fresh from the impoverished countryside, where wage labour was uncommon and the daily work rhythm was flexible, and not knowing that there were legal maximum working hours or minimum pay, the workers had little idea that they were being cheated" and were both willing to work overtime for less than minimum wage and easily fired when higher output was no longer needed.[38] These first migrant laborers, and their successors in the *dagongmei* of the 1990s,[39] set the foundation for the PRC's economic miracle under the Deng Xiaoping reforms of the 1980s and 1990s. It is precisely this success, and the methods that led to it (such as non-permanent labor, cheap labor, and replaceable labor) that Chinese managers of companies in Africa hope to emulate and are leading to these low-wage-, poor-working-condition-, and precarious jobs.

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[37] Anita Chan, "Voices from the Zhili Fire: The Tragedy of a Toy Factory and the Conditions It Exposed," in *Proletarian China*, eds. Ivan Franceschini and Christian Sorace (London:: Verso, 2022), 506.
[38] Chan, "Voices," 507, 510.
[39] Ngai Pun, "Becoming Dagongmei (Working Girls): The Politics of Identity and Difference in Reform China," *The China Journal* no. 42 (1999): 1-18.

However, these Chinese managers aren't just blindly applying the Chinese experience to their African workers out of pure delusion. In fact, economic conditions in the countries in which they work, as well as the complicated financial circumstances of the enterprises they take over, suggest that such an application is occasionally warranted. An excellent example is that of the Urafiki textile mills, whose Chinese managers are quoted above, indirectly defending the poor working conditions at the mills. These mills were originally PRC state aid projects for economic development that were first turned over to the Tanzanian government as the PRC introduced Deng's major economic reforms but then were reformed as joint ventures between the Tanzanian and PRC governments in 1995 due to major issues in running them purely locally.[40] As a result, given the original mill's focus on boosting economic development, it is no surprise that the first Chinese general manager to lead the mills, having just experienced the beginnings of the new labor regime for economic development described above, explained, "'[The Urafiki venture] could not be like foreign aid in the past. It has to be financially viable, although the joint venture is also partially politically motivated.'"[41]

This reasoning—of the need to cut labor costs to ensure the viability of the joint venture and, thus, its contribution to the economic development of the country—directly led to the switch at the Urafiki textile mills from a large permanent workforce to a much smaller temporary one and to lower wages.[42] Thus, Chinese experiences of maximizing cheap labor (and, consequently, 吃苦) in enterprises for peak profit and economic development, *combined* with Chinese managers seeing similar conditions in their African ventures as in Chinese pre-Deng experience, push managers to view cheap labor and cost cutting

[40] Tang, "Does Chinese Employment," 112.
[41] Lee, "Raw Encounters," 651-652.
[42] Lee, "Raw Encounters," 652; Tang, "Does Chinese Employment," 112.

as the best way to achieve the seemingly obvious goal of economic development. Unfortunately, unlike in the PRC during the great pushes for modernization, local African workers by and large do not share this single-minded, collective goal, leading to conflicts of expectations between managers and workers. As Tang writes, "Africans do not necessarily reject the thoughts of eating bitterness," but, he adds, "...when Chinese and local people have very different views on working conditions, tensions between employers and employees may rise."[43]

Concern #2: Lack of Hiring and Promotions for Local Africans

Like concerns over the quality of work and wage in Chinese-owned enterprises in Africa, concerns over low hiring of and a lack of promotions for local Africans in these companies are similarly widespread. As Carlos Oya and Florian Schaefer explain, Western media in particular pushes the narrative that Chinese companies in Africa are staffed solely by fellow countrymen imported directly from China itself, with some blindly asserting that Chinese workers in Africa numbered one million in the 2010s.[44] Tang agrees that the media heavily emphasizes the number of Chinese workers in Chinese-owned enterprises in Africa, pointing to several articles that claim that Chinese companies in Africa " prefer to bring a large number of Chinese workers to Africa and are unwilling to hire local workers."[45] On concerns about hiring are further built concerns about personal treatment of and lack of promotions for local Africans, which are not without substance. For example, interviews with Chinese managers in Kenya showcase their lack of faith in their African subordinates, a lack of faith in the latters' skills and capacity for hard work that they discuss in racial terms.[46] Furthermore, these same interviewees repeatedly underscore that,

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[43] Tang, "Does Chinese Employment," 114.
[44] Carlos Oya and Florian Schaefer, *Chinese Firms and Employment Dynamics in Africa: A Comparative Analysis* (London: SOAS, 2019), 14-15, https://www.almendron.com/tribuna/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/file141857.pdf.
[45] Tang, "Does Chinese Employment," 107.
[46] Zander Rounds and Hongxiang Huang, *We are not so different: A comparative study of employment relations at Chinese and American firms in Kenya* (Washington, DC: China Africa Research Initiative, 2017), 18,

because of these facts, they would never allow an African to rise to a management position.[47]

While the moral panic over Chinese workers in Africa is mostly unfounded,[48] Chinese views of African workers, as shown above, do directly impact local laborers in these firms, warranting a closer look. It is with this closer look that one notices the peculiar similarities between these Chinese managers' rhetoric on Africans and 1990s Chinese foremen's rhetoric on workers from the countryside, as studied by Ngai Pun. To be sure, Chinese managers in Africa are racializing local African workers in a different way to that of Chinese foreman with rural factory workers, but the similarities demand analysis. The Chinese managers in Kenya describe local African workers, whom they typically referred to as "black people" (黑人，hēirén) or "locals" (当地人，dāngdìrén), with the following comments:

> "Black people are unreliable. They do not have enough of a sense of responsibility and morals."
>
> "Locals' capacity is insufficient. They cannot close a deal. They work inefficiently, always delaying. They are too lazy."
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> "Locals are very apathetic. If they have an opportunity to be lazy, they will be lazy. They are not accustomed to working overtime, but after some time will slowly acclimate to an environment or be fired for their unwillingness to work overtime."[49]

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https://static1.squarespace.com/static/5652847de4b033f56d2bdc29/t/58da9416e4fcb5845eb6da4a/1490719767135/zander+v1.pdf.

[47] Rounds and Huang, *We are not*, 18 - 19.

[48] Tang's ""Does Chinese Employment," cited multiple times throughout this paper, as well as Oya and Schaefer's *Chinese Firms*, cited above, do an excellent job of gathering quantitative, rather than anecdotal, sources to prove that local workers typically make up a large portion, if not an absolute majority, of laborers in Chinese-owned companies in Africa.

[49] Rounds and Huang, *We are not*, 18-19.

In these quotes, the Chinese managers in Kenya complain about African workers' supposed laziness and lack of responsibility, similarly to the Chinese foremen in Ngai Pun's research, who see migrant workers as stupid and needing plenty of polishing to become a reliable worker. She describes that, during one of her workdays in the factory where she was conducting research, a fellow coworker was upbraided for leaving a scratch on the case of a rout-finder with the following speech: "'What the hell are you doing? You're going to spoil the casing. Such a big scratch here…You know you're not *plowing a furrow*, don't you? These products are very expensive, you couldn't pay for it even if you worked in the fields for a year. *Cushou cujiao!* [Rough hands, rough feet][Emphasis in original].'"[50] In both this quote and the quotes from the Chinese managers above, their subordinates are demeaned as not being able to perform work well.

Such rhetoric naturally makes people feel worthless—and what better way to keep labor cheap, one of the major goals of Chinese managers in Africa, as shown in the previous section, but to make people feel that they do not deserve more? It seems that, beyond buying into racial stereotypes of Africans, Chinese managers have also subconsciously or consciously appropriated this denigrating method of labor cheapening from the Chinese factory context and applied it to the African context. This claim is further supported by instances of Chinese managers attempting to manipulate local Africans by pretending not to speak English when it is inconvenient for them to know what is going on (e.g., with union demands),[51] a tactic that also seems to descend, though more liberally, from Chinese factory work, where language acts as a proxy for ruralness and thus capability and location on the workers' hierarchy, another method of labor control.[52]

Conclusion

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[50] Pun, "Becoming Dagongmei," 4.
[51] Lee, "Raw Encounters," 654.
[52] Pun, "Becoming Dagongmei," 12-13.

With China-Africa relations booming in the last two decades, and Chinese company investment and presence in Africa growing in parallel, scholarly attention has been rightfully focused on the details of relationships between local African laborers and their Chinese managers. In this paper, however, I have pushed the field to look beyond the empirical and into the historical, with the goal of contextualizing Chinese company practices in Africa in the broader history of Chinese labor practices and thus improving understanding of these complicated labor relationships today. I find that low wages and poor working conditions in Chinese enterprises derive from Chinese managers' expectations of the need to suffer to improve economic conditions in African countries, as occurred in China, and that Chinese managers' representations of African workers eerily resemble 1990s Chinese foremen's outlooks on the the rural migrant workers under them, novel perspectives on these two issues that underscore the importance of the historical perspective when analyzing new developments in Chinese labor relations abroad.

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